

Top 10 Open Source Media Server Software in 2018



A media server is simply a device that stores and shares media – audio, video, photos, books, etc. This broad definition covers a wide range of devices that can be called media servers. This article lists the top ten media server software of 2018.

In the Internet era, which is defined by online communications, the media server plays a significant role by providing a base for storing and sharing media files. It is responsible for the hardware as well as software aspects of successful storage and retrieval of files, as well as media file and data sharing. A media server can be any device with network access and adequate bandwidth for sharing and saving media files. A server, PC, NAS (network attached storage) or any device with storage capacity can be termed a media server.

A media server can be further described as follows:

- Software that enables the availability of audio, video or any other multimedia files on the network. For file discovery, a media server typically uses the Bonjour or UPnP protocols. For sharing files and managing playlists, media servers use DAAP or Windows Media Connect protocols.
- Hardware that can store music, images and videos for accessing via Wi-Fi points on smartphones, smart TVs or any handheld device.
- A computer system operational in the network to store and download all sorts of files from the Internet.

This article lists the top open source media server software, providing a one-stop guide to choose the best of the best based on individual requirements and media management capabilities.

1. Kodi

Kodi, previously known as XBMC, is free and open source media server software developed by the XBMC Foundation. It supports multiple operating systems and hardware platforms to store all digital media files in one place, and manages with the '10-foot UI' (a GUI designed especially for televisions, and uses text and other interface elements which

are much larger in order to be read from a typical television viewing distance of 3 metres or 10 feet). The core code is written in C++, with modified versions of Kodi-XBMC with JeOS. It can be used as a software appliance suite or framework in numerous devices like media players, NAS, smart TVs, set-top boxes and even embedded devices like Pi, Pine 64, etc. Kodi supports many common audio, video and image formats, playlists, audio visualisations, slide shows, weather forecasts and third-party plugins.

As a media streamer, Kodi relies mostly on add-ons, which essentially function as apps on a device such as a Roku or Apple TV.

Technical features

- **Live TV with EPG + PVR/DVR:** Kodi supports native Live TV with the electronic programme guide as well as the digital video recorder with a personal video recorder, to allow end users to capture video and play from a hard disk with PVR client add-ons.
- **Video library support:** Kodi has strong metadata video databases, and this allows end users to download and display movie information. The Library mode gives more detailed information about video content like the genre, title, year, film directors and the actors.
- **Video player:** Kodi has an FFmpeg based video player to support all video formats available till date, including CDs, DVDs and Blu-ray disks.
- **Audio support:** Kodi has its own audio player called PAAPlayer (Psycho-Acoustic Audio Player) for all audio formats and even display song lyrics.
- **Image viewer:** Kodi supports the display of all image formats including zoom features and slide shows with the Ken Burns Effect.